

ON TECHNIQUE

Piano-roll recordings

Debussy was one of the first composers to record himself performing his work. In 1913, he recorded 14 pieces on a Welte-Mignon reproducing piano, in which an electric suction pump replaces the foot bellow. This was the most sophisticated device of its kind, capturing not just the notes, but the nuances of the pianist's style for posterity, including phrasing, tempo, pedaling, and dynamics. Debussy's performance was encoded onto six piano rolls, continuous sheets of paper punched with holes, which were copied for use on player pianos.



DEBUSSY AT THE PIANO, SURROUNDED BY
MEMBERS OF HIS FAMILY, 1893

The eldest of five children, Claude Debussy was born in a Parisian suburb. His immediate family had no musical links. His father drifted through various jobs—shopkeeper, salesman,